Data Classification Procedures Guide
WyIT.2001-G2

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Policy Contact	Pat Potter, Deputy Chief Data Officer
Policy Approver	Jeff Clines, Chief Information Officer
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Next Review Date	April 1, 2027
Policy Version	2026-09.1
Associated Policy	WyIT 2001, Information Classification

Introduction:

This guide provides detailed information regarding Information Classification, supporting WyIT 2001, Information, to support Wyoming state agencies in properly classifying state information.

This standard applies to all Executive Branch agencies, boards, and commissions staff (collectively referred to as "agencies"). This standard is also applicable to consultants, affiliates, third party vendors and temporary employees that use or store data.

Authority

This guideline is promulgated under the authority of Wyoming State Statute 9-2-2906 and its subsections, the Department of Enterprise Technology Services is required to adopt and enforce information technology standards, and promote efficient use of information technology throughout state government.

Specifically, this policy is further promulgated under the authority of the below listed Wyoming State Statute subsections.

- Implements and maintains an information technology governance program for state agencies (W.S 9-2-2906,(b), (ii));
- Establishes and enforces data security and privacy policies and standards for the state data infrastructure Establishes review criteria for the agencies information technology projects, procurements and purchases. (W.S 9-2-2906,(b), (iii)); and

Adopts information technology policies and standards and ensures agency compliance with those policies and standards (W.S. 9-2-2906,(b), (vi)).

Audience

This policy applies to all Executive Branch agencies, boards, and commissions staff (collectively referred to as "agencies"). This policy is also applicable to consultants, affiliates, third party vendors and temporary employees that use or store state data.

Definitions

Key Definitions, Acronyms, and Terms

Data Governance Roles

- **Data Owner**
  - The agency or program with statutory authority and ultimate responsibility for the data.
  - Determines access rights and establishes controls.
- **Data Custodian**
  - Individual or entity responsible for the storage, maintenance, and technical safeguarding of data.
- **Data Steward**
  - Individual(s) appointed by the Data Owner to be responsible for proper data classification, quality, and management practices.

Other Key Concepts

- **Classification Inheritance**
  - The process by which compiled or derivative information takes on the highest classification level of any component information.
  - When information consists of elements with different classification levels, the entire information asset shall be classified at the highest level of any component element.
- **Aggregated Data**
  - Collections of data elements from multiple sources that may require higher classification than individual elements due to revealing patterns or sensitive insights when combined.
  - Agencies must consider whether aggregated data requires higher classification than its component parts due to mosaic effects or inference risks.

Detailed Classification System:

1. **INITIAL CLASSIFICATION**

1.1. Data Stewards shall classify information at creation or acquisition.

1.2. Classification decisions shall be documented with justification.

1.3. When classifying information, consider the following factors:

1.3.1. Sensitivity of the information and privacy implications;

1.3.2. Applicable legal and regulatory requirements (state and federal);

1.3.3. Potential impact if disclosed, modified, or unavailable;

1.3.4. Aggregation effects when combined with other information;

1.3.5. Business value and operational importance;

1.3.6. Temporal sensitivity (does classification change over time?);

1.3.7. Public disclosure requirements under W.S. §16-4-201 through §16-4-205);

1.3.8. Contractual obligations regarding confidentiality;

1.3.9. Relationship to other classified information.

2. RECLASSIFICATION

2.1. Data Stewards shall review classifications at least annually.

2.2. Classification changes must be documented with justification.

2.3. When reclassifying to a lower level, written approval from the Data Owner is required.

2.4. Consider changes in business context, regulatory environment, or aggregation effects.

3. CLASSIFICATION DISPUTE RESOLUTION

3.1. If agencies disagree on the classification of shared information, the higher classification shall apply until it is resolved.

3.2. Confidential-Standard information is sensitive business or operational information.

3.2.1. Example data types: security plans, sensitive strategic plans, contract negotiations, legal opinions, processing volumes, service pricing, equipment configurations, vendor information, application software configurations, and other similar business and technical information.

3.2.2. The Wyoming Data Governance Council shall serve as the final arbiter for classification disputes between agencies.

4. AUTOMATED CLASSIFICATION SUPPORT

4.1. Agencies are encouraged to implement data discovery tools to identify potentially sensitive information.

4.2. Where feasible, automated classification suggestions should be used to supplement manual classification decisions.

4.3. Classification metadata should be embedded in document properties where technically possible.

4.4. Visual labels or watermarks should be added to documents according to their classification level.

5. CLASSIFICATION DECISION TREE

5.1. Would disclosure of this information violate federal or state law, regulations, or contractual obligations?

5.1.1. YES → Classify as CONFIDENTIAL (determine appropriate subcategory)

5.1.2. NO → Continue to question 5.2

5.2. Would disclosure of this information potentially harm individuals, compromise operations, damage the State's reputation, or create financial/legal liability?

5.2.1. YES → Classify as CONFIDENTIAL (determine appropriate subcategory)

5.2.2. NO → Continue to question 5.3

5.3. Is this information intended for unrestricted public disclosure?

5.3.1. YES → Classify as PUBLIC

5.3.2. NO → Classify as INTERNAL

5.4. For information that does not have a pre-determined classification by statute or regulation, use the following decision path:

(When in doubt, classify at the higher level until a definitive determination can be made)

6. LABELING REQUIREMENTS

6.1. All information should be clearly labeled with its classification level.

6.2. Unlabeled information shall be considered "Internal" by default unless otherwise specified in W.S. §16-4-203.

6.3. Where technically feasible, use headers, footers, watermarks, or metadata to indicate classification.

6.4. Classification labels should be clearly visible and easily understood.

7. HANDLING PRACTICES BY CLASSIFICATION LEVEL

7.1. Public Information

7.1.1. No special handling requirements beyond normal good practices.

7.1.2. Can be freely distributed within and outside the organization.

7.1.3. No restrictions on storage or transmission methods.

7.2. Internal Information

7.2.1. Should not be disclosed to external parties without appropriate review.

7.2.2. Use standard security controls for systems containing internal information.

7.2.3. Transmission via standard email is acceptable.

7.2.4. Can be stored on state-managed systems without encryption

7.3. Confidential Information

7.3.1. Access strictly limited to authorized individuals with a need to know.

7.3.2. Strong access controls required for all systems containing confidential information.

7.3.3. Encryption required for storage and transmission.

7.3.4. Physical documents should be stored in locked containers when not in use.

7.3.5. Sharing requires appropriate approvals and secure methods.

7.3.6. Special handling procedures may apply for regulated data types.

8. IMPLEMENTATION APPROACH

8.1. Agencies should implement this classification framework using the following phased approach:

(Agencies should adjust these timelines based on their size, complexity, and available resources.)

8.2. Phase 1: Foundation (0-3 months)

8.2.1. Educate key stakeholders on classification levels and data domains;

8.2.2. Identify and document core data domains (3-5 initial domains);

8.2.3. Designate Data Owners and Data Stewards for each domain;

8.2.4. Inventory critical information assets within each domain;

8.2.5. Develop agency-specific classification procedures (if needed).

8.3. Phase 2: Classification (3-6 months)

8.3.1. Classify critical information assets starting with high-value, high-risk domains;

8.3.2. Implement labeling for classified information;

8.3.3. Establish access controls aligned with classification levels;

8.3.4. Develop monitoring mechanisms to verify proper classification;

8.3.5. Conduct initial training for all staff.

8.4. Phase 3: Integration (6-12 months)

8.4.1. Expand classification to all remaining information assets;

8.4.2. Integrate classification with related policies (retention, sharing, encryption);

8.4.3. Implement automated tools to support classification where feasible;

8.4.4. Conduct compliance verification through sampling and review;

8.4.5. Refine and expand data domains based on experience.

8.5. Phase 4: Maturity (12+ months)

8.5.1. Establish regular review cycles for classifications and domains;

8.5.2. Implement metrics and reporting on classification effectiveness;

8.5.3. Automate classification where possible;

8.5.4. Conduct advanced training for specialized roles;

8.5.5. Share best practices across agencies.

Data Handling Requirements by Classification Level:

Requirement	Public	Internal	Confidential
Access Controls	No restrictions	Basic authentication	Strong authentication + authorization
Storage Encryption	Not required	Not required	Required
Transmission Encryption	Not required	Recommended	Required
Labeling	Optional	Required	Required with subcategory
Sharing Approval	Not required	Manager approval	Data Owner approval
Storage Location	Any approved system	State-managed systems	Secured state systems only
Remote Access	Permitted	Permitted	With additional controls
Disposal Methods	Standard deletion	Clearing	Purging or destruction
Audit Logging	Not required	Basic	Comprehensive
Backup Requirements	Standard	Standard	Enhanced

Note on Retention Requirements: Classification levels do not automatically determine retention periods for information. Agencies must follow appropriate retention schedules as established by the Wyoming State Archives.

However, classification levels should inform storage methods and security controls throughout the retention period.

Applicable State Policies, Federal, State or Industry Rules, Laws, and/or Regulations

1. WyIT 2001, Information Classification
2. WyIT 2001-S1, Data Owner Standard
3. WyIT 2001-S2, Data Steward Standard
4. WyIT 2001-S3, Data Custodian Standard
5. WyIT 2001-S4, Data Domain Standard
6. WyIT 2001-GL1, Information Classification Procedures Guide

7. WyIT-2004, Information Breach, Disclosure or Data Leak
8. WyIT 2004-GL, Information Breach Response Guide
9. WyIT-2005, Information Residency and Transportation
10. WyIT-2006, Agency Official for Privacy (AOP)
11. WyIT-2011, Wyoming State Data Collection, Transparency, and Consent
12. WyIT-2013, Electronic Data Destruction and Sanitization
13. WyIT 2014, Data Sharing Agreement Documentation and Governance

Compliance & Exceptions:

Compliance

This document supports an established policy, so there are no compliance requirements.

Exceptions

Since guides are not held to a compliance standard, there are no exceptions to this standard.

Review/Approval:

Date Issued/Review Date

This policy shall be reviewed at least annually and updated / reviewed / approved as defined in the Office of Chief Information Officer (OCIO) Policy lifecycle.

The review and update process shall be coordinated by Governance, Risk and Compliance (GRC), completed by the policy owner and approved through the OCIO policy review workflow.

Approval

This policy as signed by the appropriate officer (listed below) is considered approved and enforced, per Wyoming State Statutes (W.S 9-2-2906,(b), (iii)) and (W.S. 9-2-2906,(b), (vi)).

To obtain a signed copy of this document, contact Enterprise Technology Services Governance, Risk and Compliance (ets-ocio-grc@wyo.gov).

Jeffrey Clines Officer Name	Chief Information Officer Officer Title
_____ Officer's Signature	_____ Date

Revision History

The current version of this policy, as identified in the Revision History below, supersedes all previous documents listed below.

Version	Change	Author(s)	Date of Change
2026-09.1	ETS Director signature	GRC	September 2026
2025-09.01	WyIT 2001-G1, Information Classification Guide, Updated Document Template	Pat Potter Deputy CDO	September 2025
October 2022	WyIT 2001-GL, Information Classification Guideline Replaced by ● WyIT 2001-S1, Data Owner Standard ● WyIT 2001-S2, Data Steward Standard ● WyIT 2001-S3, Data Custodian ● WyIT 2001-S4, Data Domain Standard	Wyoming Data Governance Committee	August 2024
UKN	WyIT 2001-S, Information Classification Standard Replaced by ● WyIT 2001-S1, Data Owner Standard ● WyIT 2001-S2, Data Steward Standard ● WyIT 2001-S3, Data Custodian ● WyIT 2001-S4, Data Domain Standard	Wyoming Data Governance Committee	August 2024
UKN	08100-P131, Policy Information Classification Replaced by ● WyIT 2001-S, Information Classification Standard ● WyIT 2001-GL, Information Classification Guideline	UKN	November 2018
UKN	08100-S131, Information Classification Standard Replaced by ● WyIT 2001-S, Information Classification Standard ● WyIT 2001-GL, Information Classification Guideline	UKN	May 2018